

Toggable inline review comments in orgmode LaTeX export

Rohit Goswami · 2026-03-27 · orgmode · tex · workflow

When co-authoring a paper in `orgmode` while collaborators edit the LaTeX on Overleaf, the review loop gets awkward: comments live in the `.tex`, changes happen in the `.org`, and neither side sees the other's annotations. A toggable inline comment system bridges this gap: each collaborator gets a colored command, and a single boolean flag strips all comments for submission.

In the `orgmode` preamble, define a conditional block:

```
#+LATEX_HEADER: \usepackage{xcolor}
#+LATEX_HEADER: \newif\ifshowreviewnotes
#+LATEX_HEADER: \showreviewnotestruer % change to \showreviewnotesfalse for submission
#+LATEX_HEADER: \ifshowreviewnotes
#+LATEX_HEADER: \newcommand{\mg}[1]{\color{cyan}[MG: #1]}
#+LATEX_HEADER: \newcommand{\rg}[1]{\color{green!50!black}[RG: #1]}
#+LATEX_HEADER: \else
#+LATEX_HEADER: \newcommand{\mg}[1]{}
#+LATEX_HEADER: \newcommand{\rg}[1]{}
#+LATEX_HEADER: \fi
```

Adding a new reviewer is just another `\newcommand` inside the `\ifshowreviewnotes` block – pick a color and a two-letter prefix.

Then scatter comments inline using `orgmode`'s `@@latex:...@@` syntax:

```
The reflector inverts the force component along  $\hat{\mathbf{d}}$ .
@@latex:\mg{what is d here? the dimer axis or the NEB tangent?}
\rg{Clarified:  $\hat{\mathbf{d}}$  =  $\hat{\mathbf{N}}$ } for the dimer.
Added a sentence defining the notation.}@@
```

This renders as colored bracketed text in the PDF:

- `[MG: what is d here?]` in cyan
- `[RG: Clarified: ...]` in green

The comment and reply sit right next to the text they refer to, so the conversation is spatially grounded.

When a collaborator pastes their Overleaf `\mg{...}` comments, you can drop them into the `.org` with the response and the actual fix all in the same spot.

For submission, flip the flag:

```
- \showreviewnotestruer
+ \showreviewnotesfalse
```

All `\mg`, `\rg`, etc. become no-ops – zero output, no stale comment text leaking into the published PDF, and no need to hunt through the source deleting annotations. The comments remain in the `.org` as a permanent record of the review conversation.

This pairs well with `latexdiff` for generating the highlighted-changes PDF that journals want alongside the clean submission.

